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A SUNDAY IN SHANGHAI

Formula One returned to China after four years, with Max Verstappen dominating yet again, winning both the Sprint and Grand Prix races.

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Formula One returned to China for the first time since 2019 at the Shanghai International Circuit. The previous four editions weren't held because of COVID-19 and the associated restrictions. It was also the first Sprint weekend of the season.

However, not much changed up front as Max Verstappen (left) continued to operate on a different plane from the rest of the grid as he clinched both the Sprint and Grand Prix wins.

Friday's promise fizzles

On Friday afternoon, as rain hit the circuit, Lando Norris took the Sprint pole in a mixed-up grid ahead of Lewis Hamilton, which portended some excitement. But it was just a mirage as Verstappen and Red Bull showed their supremacy on dry conditions in the sprint race on Saturday morning. The Dutchman won it with ease ahead of Hamilton and teammate Sergio Perez.

In qualifying later on Saturday, Verstappen led a Red Bull lockout of the front row while Fernando Alonso produced a stunning lap to finish third ahead of two McLarens and two Ferraris — in that order. But the big surprise was when Hamilton, who starred in the Sprint, got knocked out of the first part of the qualifying after finishing only 18th fastest. On Sunday, in a race that saw some clashes between drivers that triggered two full Safety Cars, Verstappen was untroubled. Despite losing his nearly 20-second lead at one point, the reigning champion nailed the subsequent restarts to get his 58th career victory, finishing 13 seconds ahead of the pursuing field.

Following this win, he holds a 25-point lead in the championship ahead of Perez. It was another commanding drive by the 26-year-old, and the combination of Verstappen and Red Bull is one of the most dominant pairings the sport has ever seen. As his team boss said after the race, Verstappen has won 50 per cent of all races since the last time F1 visited China in 2019.

Behind Verstappen, Norris clinched a brilliant second, helped by the fortunate timing of a virtual safety car that allowed him to jump Perez, who came third to complete the podium.

The Mexican dropped a place at the start to Alonso and, despite retaking it a few laps later, came out behind Norris and Leclerc after the first round of pit stops. Once the race restarted following the Safety Car periods, Perez couldn't quickly get rid of Leclerc and when he eventually passed the Ferrari on lap 39, the McLaren driver had built a five-second lead. Despite his best efforts, Perez could not get close to Norris and had to settle for third.